remark (even in hindsight) that the co-existing differences among these Shansabani presences outside Ghur seem to serve as harbingers presaging the later, larger-scale and yet distinctly region-specific modes of "conquest" along the banks of the Indus and beyond (cf. Chapter 6, and Volume II).

As discussed in Chapter 1, the Shansabanis' quickly increasing sphere of influence was not necessarily the outcome of a strategy emanating from a "center." Rather, it seems frequently to have been the result of *ad hoc* and piecemeal campaigns from the newly invested appanages. Their architectural patronage would buoy this understanding. But, recreating the precise process of expansion is made all the more difficult by various aspects of the *textual* sources closest to the events. The prime among these sources would of course be Juzjani's *Tabaqat* of the mid-thirteenth century, along with surviving near-contemporaneous works belonging to various other genres.[4]

One challenging aspect of Juzjani's *Tabaqat* (as well as other texts) may seem merely mechanical, but it is far from immaterial. In addition to the still cautious identification of Firuzkuh,[5] the majority of places Juzjani named as the Shansabani brothers' appanages are as yet only conjecturally located. For example, the precise whereabouts and extent of the territory of Warshada, the appanage of 'Izz al-Din's second son Qutb al-Din Muhammad – the eventual "founder" of Firuzkuh – are unknown.[6] Although, Qutb al-Din's subsequent search "in [various] directions for a place to build a well-fortified stronghold and a wondrous city as a capital" could indicate that Warshada was in the vicinity of Jam-Firuzkuh. Ultimately, Qutb al-Din's selection of this locale as his seat attested to his acuity and foresight, given the more stable, commerce-based prosperity of the settlement and its vicinity.[7]

Aside from Warshada's hypothetical location, only Kashi and Wajiristan can be identified. Kashi was the appanage of Fakhr al-Din Mas'ud, 'Izz al-Din's eldest son, and can be surmised as a part of or near modern Chaghcharan (capital of present-day Ghur Province). Wajiristan, the appanage of 'Ala' al-Din Husain *Jahan-suz* (the "World Incendiary"; see below), was apparently located directly west of Ghazna. But the appanages of 'Izz al-Din's other sons – *viz.* Madin, given to Nasir al-Din Muhammad; Sanga to Baha' al-Din (d. AH 544/1149 CE); and even the Istiya of Saif al-Din himself – are only approximately locatable, if at all.[8]

Early Firuzkuh

By the time of 'Ala' al-Din Husain *Jahan-suz*'s vengeful and supposedly spectacular destruction of Ghazna and Bust-Lashkari Bazar in AH 544/1150 CE, his older half-brother Qutb al-Din had already initiated a Shansabani